



08 | When I Struggle: Overwhelm, Shutdown, Recovery



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8.1 What It Looks Like:

- Silence, confusion, forgetfulness, frustration
- Delays in response, missed deadlines, disconnection

8.2 What Doesn't Help:

- Guilt-tripping
- “Just do it” pressure
- Surprises or emotional dumping

8.3 What Does Help:

- Re-centering together: “Want to pause and reset?”
- Space to decompress
- Time-blocking with built-in flexibility



When Cody experiences overwhelm, it manifests in specific ways that are influenced by their intersecting identities:

Signs of Overwhelm:

- They may become silent, confused, and forgetful
- Their communication may slow down, leading to delayed responses and missed deadlines

What Makes Things Worse:

- Guilt-tripping or pressure tactics can be particularly harmful, especially given their PTSD and neurodivergent needs
- Unexpected changes or emotional overload ("emotional dumping") can be destabilizing

Effective Support Strategies:

- Offering collaborative reset opportunities ("Want to pause and reset?") helps maintain connection while respecting boundaries
- Providing space for decompression is crucial for their emotional regulation
- Using time-blocking with built-in flexibility helps accommodate their ADHD needs while maintaining structure

This pattern of overwhelm and recovery needs to be understood within the context of their multiple intersecting identities - as someone who is transgender, neurodivergent, and managing both ADHD and PTSD, these responses are protective mechanisms rather than signs of disengagement.